

CHAPTER 7

CAUSE / EFFECT PARAGRAPHS

OBJECTIVES

To write academic texts, you need to master certain skills.

In this chapter, you will learn to:

- Identify causes and effects
- Organize cause / effect paragraphs
- Write supporting sentences to explain multiple causes or multiple effects
- Use transition signals to express cause / effect relationships
- Write, revise, and edit a cause or an effect paragraph about a social issue



INTRODUCTION

In Chapter 6, you learned about definition paragraphs. Chapter 7 shows how to write cause / effect paragraphs. Analyzing causes and effects is an important part of academic thinking and writing. For example, a professor may ask you to examine the causes of a war, the factors that led to a company's success, or the effects a new technology or a scientific discovery has had on daily life. At the end of Chapter 7, you will write your own cause or effect paragraph.

ORGANIZATION

Like the paragraphs you have learned about in previous chapters, cause / effect paragraphs should have a topic sentence, supporting sentences, and one or more concluding sentences. In addition, a good cause / effect paragraph focuses on why something happened (the causes) and what happened as a result (the effects).

ANALYZING THE MODEL

The writing model discusses three factors that led to the success of a bike rental system.

Read the model. Then answer the questions

Writing Model

What Paved the Way for Vélib's Success?

1 Vélib' has become the world's most successful bike sharing program since it was introduced in Paris in 2007. 2 There are three important causes for the success of Vélib'. 3 First, Paris leaders planned carefully to avoid missteps. 4 They analyzed where local residents and tourists were most likely to use bicycles. 5 Vélib' planners then selected convenient locations for bike stations near bus stops and subway entrances. 6 They also decided to have a distance of just 300 yards from one station to the next. 7 The short distance allows cyclists to pick up and return their bikes easily. 8 Second, the Paris government made Vélib' bikes affordable for riders with the cooperation of a large advertising company. 9 Because the company agreed to pay for the Vélib' bike stations and 20,000 bicycles in exchange for advertising space, a one-day pass costs just \$2.15. 10 With this prepaid ticket, cyclists can have an unlimited number of 30-minute rides. 11 Finally, Vélib' has been successful because of effective publicity. 12 The Paris leaders created an image of bicycles as a vehicle for the future rather than an outdated mode of transportation. 13 In a fashion capital, they convinced people that bikes are fashionable. 14 All in all, Vélib' has succeeded as a result of thorough planning, creative financing, and powerful marketing.

Questions about the Model

1. Underline the topic sentence. Does the paragraph focus on causes (why something happened) or effects (what happened as a result)?
2. Underline the three main points of the paragraph.
3. In Sentence 9, is the word *because* introducing a cause or an effect?

TOPIC SENTENCES IN CAUSE

PARAGRAPHS

The topic sentence of a cause paragraph should state the topic and the controlling idea about the topic. The controlling idea should let readers know whether the focus of the paragraph is on why something happened-

CAUSES There are three important causes for the success of Vélip'.

It can also include synonyms such as *"reasons", "factors", "explanations", and "justifications"*

PRACTICE 2

Writing Topic Sentences

Read each paragraph. Circle the topic sentence that best presents the topic and controlling idea. Then write it on the line.

PARAGRAPH 1

At the Heart of the Exercise Problem

_____ The first cause of the problem is the physical ease brought about by modern conveniences. For example, today, people drive their cars instead of walking, even when they are going a short distance. At school and at work, they ride elevators instead of taking the stairs and then sit for hours at a desk in front of a computer. A second explanation for the lack of physical exercise is time. Many people today are busy working, studying, and taking care of their families. As a result, they have little time to go to the gym or play sports. Finally, an important cause of the problem is attitude. Some people are not interested in getting exercise, so they do not make an effort to get moving. Others feel that they are too old or too out of shape to begin an exercise program.



- The problem of not getting enough exercise has three basic causes.
- Getting enough exercise is a problem for many people.
- A lack of physical exercise can have negative effects on people's health.
- Playing sports is an excellent way to get exercise.

PARAGRAPH 2

Why Hybrids Are on the Rise

_____ A belief in environmental protection is perhaps the primary factor when people choose a hybrid. Hybrid cars use a combination of gas and other fuels such as electricity. Therefore, they consume less gas and release less carbon dioxide than cars with traditional gasoline engines. As a result, hybrids cause less air pollution and less harm to the environment. The second factor that drives consumers to buy hybrids is the desire to save money. With fuel prices on the increase, motorists are looking for cars with better mileage, and hybrids offer a good solution. For example, in city driving, a Toyota Prius can go 53 miles on one gallon of gas, but a Toyota Corolla with a traditional engine gets only 27 miles per gallon. Because hybrids use less gas, they are good not only for the environment but also for the wallet. The third factor that causes consumers to buy a hybrid is simply the cool factor. Certain car buyers like the idea of having an automobile with modern technology. They want to drive a vehicle that is new and different. Owning a hybrid makes these consumers feel special.

SUPPORTING SENTENCES IN CAUSE

PARAGRAPHS

When you gather supporting information for a cause paragraph, you first identify main causes related to your topic. Then you organize the causes or in a logical way.

(From the most obvious/important cause to the least obvious/ important one;
from the earliest to the latest cause)

- **Main points:** The main causes organized in a logical order
- **Supporting details:** Further explanation and description of each cause

PRACTICE 3

Please have a look back at *Paragraph 2* in the previous page. Highlight the supporting details for each cause.

SIGNALS TO SHOW CAUSES			
Sentence Connectors	Coordinating Conjunctions	Subordinating Conjunctions	Others
	for	because since as	because of due to as a result of

Coordinating Conjunctions

2. Put a comma after the first simple sentence in a compound sentence (before the coordinating conjunction).

It is better to use a cloth shopping bag, for the plastic bags that most stores give cannot be recycled.

Subordinating Conjunctions

1. Subordinating conjunctions join an independent clause and a dependent clause in a complex sentence.

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
I bring my lunch from home in reusable bags and containers

DEPENDENT CLAUSE
because I can reuse the bag and container.

2. The dependent clause can come before or after an independent clause.

DEPENDENT CLAUSE
Since items are usually transported to a recycling center by truck,

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
recycling puts some pollution into the air.

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
Recycling puts some pollution into the air

DEPENDENT CLAUSE
since items are usually transported to a recycling center by truck.

3. Use a comma when a dependent clause comes before an independent clause.

DEPENDENT CLAUSE
Because recycling causes pollution,

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
precycling is better for the environment.

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
Precycling is better for the environment

DEPENDENT CLAUSE
because recycling causes pollution.

Others

1. *Because of, due to, and as a result of* are prepositions. Use them before nouns, noun phrases, or pronouns to make prepositional phrases.

PREP.
I prefer to precycle **because of** the small size of my apartment.

NOUN

2. A prepositional phrase can come before or after an independent clause.

PREP. PHRASE
Due to the size of my apartment,

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
I have no place to keep empty plastic bottles and cans.

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
I have no place to keep empty plastic bottles and cans

PREP. PHRASE
due to the size of my apartment.

3. Use a comma when a prepositional phrase comes before an independent clause.

PREP. PHRASE
As a result of my decision to precycle,

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
I have a green lifestyle.

INDEPENDENT CLAUSE
I have a green lifestyle

PREP. PHRASE
as a result of my decision to precycle.

one/another cause of/reason for

Bad weather was **another reason for** the delay.

PRACTICE 8**Combining Sentences with Cause****Signals**

Combine the ideas in each pair of sentences to make one or two sentences. Use the transition signal in parentheses. Capitalize and punctuate the sentences correctly. Reword the sentences as needed.

1. Sunlight damages human skin. **(because)**

Too much sunlight is not good.

Because sunlight damages human skin, too much sunlight is not good.

4. Vitamin D is important. **(because of)**

Vitamin D has a role in bone development.

6. Some psychologists recommend spending time in the sun. **(for)**

Sunshine makes their patients feel happier.

7. There is a decrease in sunlight in winter. **(due to)**

Seasonal Affective Disorder, SAD, affects people in many parts of the world.

8. People spend time outdoors on sunny days. **(since)**

People are more likely to be physically active and get the exercise they need.

**ACTIVITY 8 | Using connectors and transitions**

Complete the sentences with your own ideas.

2. Because of _____, student scores on reading tests are declining.

4. More young athletes are getting injured due to _____

5. Too much sun exposure can cause cancer. Another cause of cancer is _____

PRACTICE 10

Please use the learned *cause signals* to write sentences as required

3. Why electronic dictionaries are popular with English language students

5. A cause of traffic accidents

CONCLUDING SENTENCES IN CAUSE

PARAGRAPHS

In the concluding sentences of a cause paragraph, you may do one or more of the following:

1. Restate your controlling idea about the topic.

In short, several key strategies caused Vélib's success.

2. Summarize the main causes

All in all, Vélib's success is the result of thorough planning, powerful marketing, and a commitment to convenience and affordability.

PRACTICE 6

Writing Concluding Sentences

Read the paragraph. Then write an appropriate concluding sentence on the line.

Why Hybrids Are on the Rise

There are three important factors behind the increase in popularity of hybrid cars. A belief in environmental protection is perhaps the primary factor when people choose a hybrid. Hybrid cars use a combination of gas and other fuels such as electricity. Therefore, they consume less gas and release less carbon dioxide than cars with traditional gasoline engines. As a result, hybrids cause less air pollution and less harm to the environment. The second factor that drives consumers to buy hybrids is the desire to save money. With fuel prices on the increase, motorists are looking for cars with better mileage, and hybrids offer a good solution. For example, in city driving, a Toyota Prius can go 53 miles on one gallon of gas, but a Toyota Corolla with a traditional engine gets only 27 miles per gallon. Because hybrids use less gas, they are good not only for the environment but also for the wallet. The third factor that causes consumers to buy a hybrid is simply the cool factor. Certain car buyers like the idea of having an automobile with modern technology. They want to drive a vehicle that is new and different. Owning a hybrid makes these consumers feel special.

PARAGRAPH 2

At the Heart of the Exercise Problem

The problem of not getting enough exercise has 3 basic causes.

_____ The first cause of the problem is the physical ease brought about by modern conveniences. For example, today, people drive their cars instead of walking, even when they are going a short distance. At school and at work, they ride elevators instead of taking the stairs and then sit for hours at a desk in front of a computer. A second explanation for the lack of physical exercise is time. Many people today are busy working, studying, and taking care of their families. As a result, they have little time to go to the gym or play sports. Finally, an important cause of the problem is attitude. Some people are not interested in getting exercise, so they do not make an effort to get moving. Others feel that they are too old or too out of shape to begin an exercise program. _____



TEMPLATE FOR A PARAGRAHP THAT DISCUSS THE CAUSES OF AN ISSUE

Today,(*reporting the issue*)...There are several important reasons that can explain this trend.

The first cause is _____. This means that _____. (For example, _____).

Another important reason is that _____. This happens because _____. (For instance, _____).

Finally, _____. This can lead to _____. (One clear example is _____).

In conclusion, _____ is caused by several factors, and it will continue to _____ unless

WRITING ASSIGNMENT

Write a paragraph of 150-200 words in length to analyze *the reasons why today youths turn to their friends instead of their parents for advice*

English Phrase / Collocation	Vietnamese Translation
young people / youths	giới trẻ
turn to someone for advice	tìm đến ai đó để xin lời khuyên
rely on their friends	dựa vào bạn bè
feel more comfortable with...	cảm thấy thoải mái hơn với...
have similar experiences	có những trải nghiệm giống nhau
understand each other better	hiểu nhau hơn
be closer in age	gần tuổi hơn
share the same interests	có cùng sở thích
face similar problems	đối mặt với những vấn đề giống nhau
build strong friendships	xây dựng tình bạn bền chặt
spend a lot of time together	dành nhiều thời gian bên nhau
communicate easily	giao tiếp dễ dàng
parents are too busy	cha mẹ quá bận rộn
lack of communication	thiếu sự giao tiếp
generation gap	khoảng cách thế hệ
have different ways of thinking	có cách suy nghĩ khác nhau
feel judged by parents	cảm thấy bị bố mẹ phán xét
feel pressure from parents	cảm thấy áp lực từ cha mẹ
want independence	muốn tự lập
prefer to talk to friends	thích nói chuyện với bạn bè hơn
search for emotional support	tìm kiếm sự hỗ trợ về mặt cảm xúc

English Phrase / Collocation	Vietnamese Translation
need someone who listens	cần ai đó lắng nghe
feel more understood	cảm thấy được thấu hiểu hơn
peer influence	ảnh hưởng của bạn bè
strong need to fit in	nhu cầu mạnh mẽ để hòa nhập
be afraid of disappointing parents	sợ làm cha mẹ thất vọng
avoid conflict at home	tránh xung đột trong gia đình
modern lifestyle	lối sống hiện đại
social media strengthens friendships	mạng xã hội làm tình bạn thêm gắn kết
ask for advice online	hỏi xin lời khuyên trên mạng

2. Fill-in-the-Blank with the suitable phrases from the above table

A. Fill in the blanks with the correct phrases from the list.

- Many young people _____ their friends when they need help.
- Youths often _____ with their friends because they are the same age.
- Parents are sometimes _____, so they cannot talk to their children often.
- The _____ makes communication between parents and children difficult.
- Many students _____ the same problems at school.
- Teenagers want emotional support and _____ who listens.
- Some young people feel _____ by their parents.
- Social media _____ friendships today.
- Many youths have a _____ to fit in with their peers.
- Some teenagers prefer to _____ advice online.

B. Match the phrases to their Vietnamese meaning.

a. muốn tự lập	1. peer influence
b. cảm thấy được thấu hiểu hơn	2. lack of communication
c. tránh xung đột trong gia đình	3. feel more understood
d. thiếu sự giao tiếp	4. want independence
e. ảnh hưởng của bạn bè	5. avoid conflict at home

Mind map for writing

Reasons Why Youths Turn to Peers for Advice

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FRIENDSHIP FACTORS

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- feel more comfortable
- closer in age
- similar experiences
- face similar problems
- spend a lot of time
- communicate easily
- feel more understood

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FAMILY FACTORS

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- parents are too busy
- lack of communication
- generation gap
- feel judged by parents
- feel pressure from parents

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SOCIAL FACTORS

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- peer influence
- strong need to fit in
- social media strengthens
- ask for advice online
- modern lifestyle